MAHATMA GANHI UNIVERSITY , KOTTAYAM.

MGU-UGP (Honours) MGU-BBA (Honours) MGU-BCA (Honours)

REGULAR EXAMINATION October 2026.

fifth SEMESTER

Discipline specific Core course - MG5DSCPHL301-**RATIONALISM**.

Duration 2 hrs

maximum marks :70

PART A

Short answer

Answer any **8** questions.

Each question carries 2 marks

1. Descartes holds that an idea is clear when it is present and evident to the attentive mind, and distinct when it is precise and clearly separated from other ideas. Clear and distinct ideas serve as the criterion of truth.

2. Descartes argues that thinking proves the existence of the mind. His statement “I think, therefore I am” establishes that the mind exists whenever it thinks.

3. Spinozistic substance is self-caused, exists independently, and is infinite and eternal. It possesses infinite attributes, of which thought and extension are known to human beings.

4. Apperception is the conscious awareness of one’s perceptions. It distinguishes conscious mental states from unconscious or obscure perceptions.

5. The cogito is regarded as indubitable because even doubting requires thinking. Therefore, the existence of the thinker cannot be denied while thinking is taking place.

6.Descartes argues that the idea of an infinite and perfect being exists in his mind. Since he is finite and imperfect, he cannot be the ultimate cause of this idea; therefore, God must exist as its cause.

7.Mind-body dualism holds that the mind and body are two distinct substances. The mind is a thinking, non-extended substance, whereas the body is an extended, non-thinking substance.

8.Spinoza defines substance as that which exists in itself and is conceived through itself. He maintains that there is only one substance, God or Nature, of which everything else is a mode.

9.Leibniz's principle of the identity of indiscernibles states that no two distinct things can possess exactly the same properties. If two things share all their properties, they must be identical.

10.The doctrine states that mind and body do not directly interact with each other. Instead, God has established a harmony between them so that their states correspond perfectly.

11.A clear idea is one that is present and evident to the attentive mind. A distinct idea is precise and sharply separated from other ideas, free from confusion.

12. Mind-body interactionism is the view that the mind and body, though distinct substances, interact with each other. Descartes associated this interaction with the pineal gland, which he considered the principal seat of their interaction.

PART B

short essay.

Answer any **6** questions

Each question carries 5 marks

13. Immediate modes arise directly from the absolute nature of God's attributes, while mediate modes arise through the influence of other modes. In Spinoza's philosophy, motion and rest are examples of immediate modes of extension, whereas the particular arrangements of physical things are mediate modes. Both belong to Natura Naturata, the totality of things that follow from God or Nature.

14. Leibniz distinguishes between obscure perceptions, clear perceptions, and conscious awareness or apperception. Simple monads possess obscure perceptions, while animal souls have memory and more distinct perceptions. Rational souls, or spirits, possess reason and apperception, enabling self-consciousness and reflection.

15. Descartes identifies thought and extension as the two principal attributes of created substances. Thought is the essential attribute of mind, while extension in length, breadth, and depth is the essential attribute of body. They are distinct and independent in their essential nature, although Descartes maintains that the mind and body interact in human beings.

16. Descartes holds that innate ideas are present in the mind by its very nature and are not derived from sensory experience. The mind discovers these ideas through intellectual reflection and reasoning. Examples include the ideas of God, mathematical truths, and certain fundamental principles.

17. The expression Deus sive Natura means “God or Nature” and expresses Spinoza’s belief that God and Nature are one and the same reality. He rejects the idea of a transcendent creator separate from the universe and maintains that everything exists within the one infinite substance. Individual things are modes of this single substance, which exists through itself.

18. Spinoza adopts a geometrical method in which philosophical arguments are presented through definitions, axioms, propositions, and demonstrations. Demonstrations establish the truth of propositions by deriving them logically from previously accepted principles. This method aims to provide philosophy with the systematic certainty associated with mathematics.

19.Leibniz was influenced by scholastic philosophy, particularly its concepts of substance, form, and metaphysical explanation. He combined these traditional ideas with modern developments in mathematics, physics, and rationalist philosophy. His theory of monads and principle of sufficient reason reflect his attempt to construct a systematic modern metaphysics.

20.Spinoza maintains that the order and connection of ideas are the same as the order and connection of things. The mental and physical worlds are two expressions of the same underlying reality, viewed through the attributes of thought and extension. Therefore, mental events and bodily events correspond without directly causing one another.

21.Modern rationalism emerged during the seventeenth century in response to the search for certainty and reliable knowledge. Developments in mathematics and the scientific revolution encouraged philosophers to emphasise reason, logical deduction, and clear principles. René Descartes, Baruch Spinoza, and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz became the leading representatives of this movement.

22.Descartes’ major philosophical aim was to establish a secure foundation for knowledge by overcoming doubt and uncertainty. He developed the method of systematic doubt to identify truths that could not be questioned, beginning with the cogito. He sought to use these certain foundations to establish further knowledge about the self, God, and the external world.

PART C

Essay

Answer any **2** questions.

Each question carries 12 marks

23. Spinoza’s doctrine of intellectual love of God (Amor Dei Intellectualis) refers to the highest form of love arising from the rational understanding of God or Nature. It develops through adequate knowledge, which enables the mind to understand things through their true causes and necessary connections. Intuitive knowledge, the highest level of knowledge, allows us to

understand particular things as expressions of the infinite nature of God. Through this understanding, the mind recognises that everything follows necessarily from the nature of God. Intellectual love of God brings lasting joy, freedom from passive emotions, and a deeper understanding of our place in the universe.

24. Leibniz's law of sufficient reason states that every fact or truth must have a sufficient reason why it is so rather than otherwise. Necessary truths are truths whose opposites involve a contradiction, and they can be established through logical analysis and the principle of contradiction. Contingent truths are truths whose opposites are possible, even though they are actually true. Their sufficient reasons are found in the circumstances, causes, and choices that explain why they occur, ultimately depending on God's wisdom and choice of the best possible world. Thus, necessary truths rest on logical necessity, whereas contingent truths require sufficient reasons that explain their actual existence without making them logically necessary.

25. Descartes begins his method of doubt by questioning beliefs that may contain even the slightest uncertainty. First, he uses the argument from sensory illusion, noting that the senses sometimes deceive us. Second, the dream argument suggests that he cannot always distinguish waking experience from dreaming. These arguments lead him to suspend judgment on all beliefs that can be doubted until he discovers an absolutely certain foundation for knowledge.

26. Descartes defines substance as something that exists in such a way that it does not depend on anything else for its existence, a definition that applies strictly to God alone. Infinite substance refers to God, who is eternal, infinite, omnipotent, and completely independent. Finite substances are created substances that depend on God for their existence. Descartes identifies two principal kinds of finite substance: mind, whose essential attribute is thought, and body, whose essential attribute is extension. Although mind and body are distinct in nature, Descartes maintains that they interact in human beings.